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Re-examining the South African labour force surveys

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Abstract: Since the advent of democracy, Statistics South Africa (StatsSA) has been collecting comprehensive labour market data with the October Household Survey (1995-1999), Labour Force Survey (2000-2007) and Quarterly Labour Force Survey (2008 –). In addition, the Census and other surveys have also been capturing some labour market data. In August 2025, StatsSA announced that the revamped Quarterly Labour Force Survey would be launched in the third quarter of the year, with various changes to define and derive some labour market status variables differently. This study is timely by aiming to provide further suggestions on possible changes that can still be made to the Quarterly Labour Force Survey questionnaire so as to capture labour market information even better.

1. Introduction

Before the democratic transition, the only available data sources that provide information on South Africa's labour market activities were the Project for Statistics on Living Standards and Development (which only took place once in 1993), October Household Survey (OHS)¹ and Census². Since the advent of democracy, whilst the OHS (1995-1999), Labour Force Survey (LFS) (2000-2007) and Quarterly Labour Force Survey (QLFS) (2008 –) are the surveys that captured comprehensive information on labour market activities of the population, various new surveys were introduced by Statistics South Africa (StatsSA) and they also captured labour market information to some extent. In addition, two national panel datasets (to be explained later) also captured data on labour market activities, despite not being undertaken by StatsSA.

StatsSA announced in July 2025 that the revamped QLFS would be launched in the third quarter of the year, with some changes being introduced to define and derive certain labour market outcome variables differently (for detailed explanation on these changes, refer to StatsSA (2025)). Nonetheless, despite these changes, it appears there is still room for the QLFS questionnaire design to be improved further. Thus, this research study is timely by aiming to investigate how the QLFS questionnaire can be amended and improved further, to capture comprehensive labour market information even better.

The outline of this paper is as follows: Section 2 will provide a snapshot of the South African labour market since the introduction of the QLFS in 2008, while Section 3 will explain the key sources of surveys and censuses that captured labour market data. Finally, Section 4 will provide suggestions on how the QLFS questionnaire can be improved further.

2. South African labour market levels and trends, 2008-2025

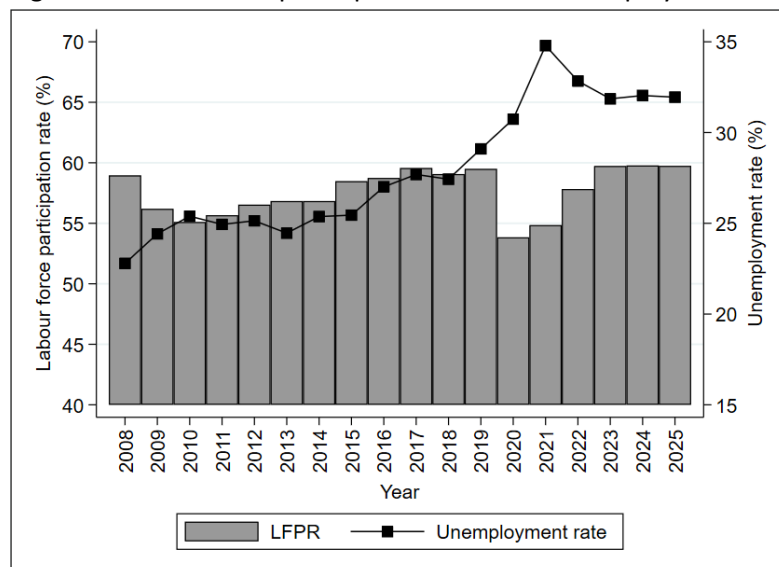
Figure 1 shows that South Africa's labour force participation rate (LFPR) increased steadily from 56.1% in 2009 to 59.5% in 2019. COVID-19-driven lockdowns contributed to abrupt declines to less than 55% in 2020 and 2021, but the LFPR subsequently increased from 57.8% in 2022 to 59.7% in 2025.

Unemployment rate statistics show rather worrying signs, as this rate increased between 2008 (22.8%) and 2025 (31.9%). In fact, one of the key labour market goals of the National Development Plan (NDP) of reducing unemployment to 14% by 2020 was not achieved (it was 30.7% in 2020 – even though it is understandable that this rate was so high in 2020 due to the harshest COVID-19 lockdown rules being imposed, and subsequently causing negative impact on the country's economy; however, the 2019 unemployment rate was 29.1% which was still way above the 14% target rate). It is also obvious that the other key labour market goal of the NDP to reduce the unemployment rate to 6% by 2030 would not happen, unless the economy can miraculously drop this rate by 5.2 percentage points annually in the next five years. In fact, even the respective primary labour market goals of the Accelerated and Shared Growth Initiative for South Africa (AsgiSA) (reducing the unemployment rate to 15% by 2014) and New Growth Path (NGP) (reducing the unemployment rate to 15% by 2020) were both not attained.

¹ In the OHS 1993-1994, people from the Transkei, Bophuthatswana, Venda, and Ciskei (TBVC) states were excluded from the sample (Yu, 2007).

² Before the advent of democracy, Census took place in 1960, 1970, 1980, 1985 and 1991. In these Censuses, some questions were asked to capture the labour market outcomes of the household members.

Figure 1: Labour force participation rates and unemployment rates, 2008-2025

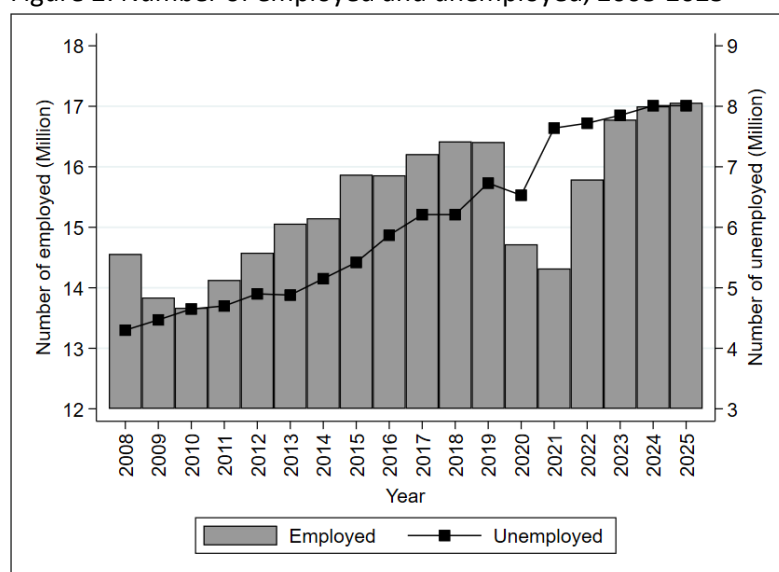


Source: Author's own calculations using the QLFS 2008-2025 third quarter data.

Next, Figure 2 shows that despite the number of employed increasing by 2.5 million between 2008 (14.6 million) and 2025 (17.1 million), the number of unemployed increased more rapidly by 3.7 million during the same period (2008: 4.3 million; 2025: 8.0 million). In other words, the extent of job creation has not been rapid enough to absorb all net entrants into the labour force. Also, whilst the NGP aimed to create five million jobs between 2010 and 2020, at the end employment only increased by approximately one million during this 10-year period.

Lastly, whilst not shown in the figure, during the 2008-2025 period, the target growth rate was 142.8%, actual growth rate was 79.5% and employment absorption rate was only 55.8% (For detailed explanation of these three rates, refer to Oosthuizen (2006: 17-18)). The latter rate means that for every 100 entrants into the labour force who actively sought work, only 56 found jobs.

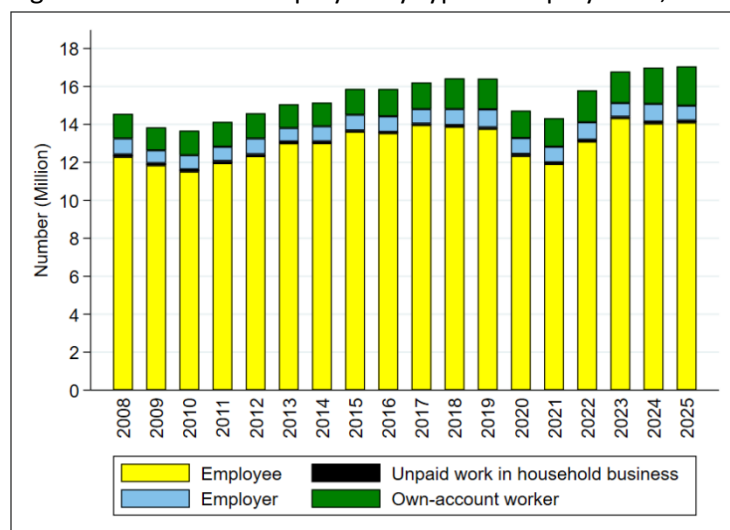
Figure 2: Number of employed and unemployed, 2008-2025



Source: Author's own calculations using the QLFS 2008-2025 third quarter data.

Figure 3 and Table 1 show the breakdown of employed by type of employment, and the results show that approximately 85% of them were employees, a negligible share of about 0.5% were involved in unpaid work in household businesses, and the remaining 14.5% were entrepreneurs as they were either employers (about 5%) or own-account workers (approximately 9.5% - although this share has been showing a slight upward trend in recent years as shown in the last few rows of Table 1).

Figure 3: Number of employed by type of employment, 2008-2025



Source: Author's own calculations using the QLFS 2008-2025 third quarter data.

Table 1: Type of employment, 2008-2025

	Employee		Unpaid worker in household business		Employer		Own-account worker		All employed	
	Number (1 000s)	%	Number (1 000s)	%	Number (1 000s)	%	Number (1 000s)	%	Number (1 000s)	%
2008	12 287	84.38	133	0.91	837	5.75	1 304	8.95	14 561	100.00
2009	11 840	85.54	121	0.87	670	4.84	1 211	8.75	13 842	100.00
2010	11 510	84.20	122	0.89	746	5.46	1 291	9.44	13 669	100.00
2011	11 960	84.63	114	0.81	745	5.27	1 313	9.29	14 132	100.00
2012	12 328	84.54	104	0.71	825	5.65	1 326	9.09	14 583	100.00
2013	13 003	86.33	97	0.65	708	4.70	1 253	8.32	15 062	100.00
2014	13 011	85.90	96	0.63	792	5.23	1 247	8.23	15 146	100.00
2015	13 613	85.79	72	0.45	821	5.18	1 361	8.58	15 867	100.00
2016	13 533	85.31	68	0.43	825	5.20	1 438	9.06	15 864	100.00
2017	13 962	86.13	82	0.51	762	4.70	1 405	8.67	16 212	100.00
2018	13 871	84.46	93	0.57	844	5.14	1 615	9.84	16 424	100.00
2019	13 763	83.87	86	0.52	945	5.76	1 617	9.85	16 411	100.00
2020	12 337	83.80	108	0.74	832	5.65	1 445	9.81	14 723	100.00
2021	11 914	83.17	86	0.60	822	5.74	1 504	10.50	14 325	100.00
2022	13 091	82.89	106	0.67	913	5.78	1 683	10.66	15 793	100.00
2023	14 328	85.38	78	0.47	718	4.28	1 658	9.88	16 782	100.00
2024	14 042	82.62	107	0.63	930	5.47	1 916	11.27	16 995	100.00
2025	14 093	82.63	117	0.69	776	4.55	2 069	12.13	17 055	100.00

Source: Author's own calculations using the QLFS 2008-2025 third quarter data.

Next, Table 2 shows that as far as the formal non-agricultural sector is concerned, over 90% of the employed in this sector worked as employees. In contrast, it can be seen from Table 3 that less than 40% of employed in the informal non-agricultural sector worked as employees, but about 50% of them were own-account workers whereas slightly over 10% were employers. These findings suggest that entrepreneurial activities were more prevalent in the informal sector.

Table 2: Type of employment in formal non-agricultural sector, selected years

	Employee	Unpaid worker in household business	Employer	Own-account worker	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets					
2008	9 385 (92.73)	50 (0.50)	532 (5.25)	154 (1.52)	10 121 (100.00)
2012	9 669 (93.70)	33 (0.32)	463 (4.49)	154 (1.49)	10 320 (100.00)
2016	10 405 (94.18)	22 (0.20)	451 (4.08)	171 (1.55)	11 049 (100.00)
2020	9 679 (93.76)	29 (0.28)	462 (4.48)	153 (1.48)	10 324 (100.00)
2024	10 795 (92.93)	38 (0.33)	537 (4.62)	246 (2.12)	11 617 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

Table 3: Type of employment in informal non-agricultural sector, selected years

	Employee	Unpaid worker in household business	Employer	Own-account worker	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets					
2008	853 (37.38)	72 (3.15)	255 (11.17)	1 102 (48.29)	2 282 (100.00)
2012	799 (34.24)	66 (2.83)	321 (13.76)	1 147 (49.16)	2 333 (100.00)
2016	1 045 (39.46)	43 (1.63)	315 (11.91)	1 244 (47.00)	2 648 (100.00)
2020	854 (34.61)	67 (2.72)	301 (12.20)	1 245 (50.47)	2 466 (100.00)
2024	1 241 (37.53)	64 (1.92)	365 (11.05)	1 637 (49.50)	3 307 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

Looking at other results, Table 4 shows that when it comes to the work sector of employers, about 60% of them operated their businesses in the formal sector and the remaining 40% in the informal sector. In contrast, Table 5 suggests that only approximately 12% of own-account workers conducted their business activities in the formal sector, that is, most own-account workers worked in the informal sector (about 88%).

Table 4: Work sector of employers, selected years

	Formal non-agricultural	Informal non-agricultural	Formal agricultural	Informal agricultural	Private households	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets						
2008	532 (63.52)	255 (30.46)	42 (5.02)	6 (0.70)	3 (0.31)	837 (100.00)
2012	463 (56.21)	321 (38.95)	32 (3.87)	6 (0.68)	2 (0.30)	825 (100.00)
2016	451 (54.62)	315 (38.23)	47 (5.73)	10 (1.20)	2 (0.22)	825 (100.00)
2020	462 (55.55)	301 (36.14)	44 (5.34)	18 (2.18)	7 (0.79)	832 (100.00)
2024	537 (57.76)	365 (39.29)	17 (1.81)	7 (0.74)	4 (0.39)	930 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

Table 5: Work sector of own-account workers, selected years

	Formal non-agricultural	Informal non-agricultural	Formal agricultural	Informal agricultural	Private households	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets						
2008	154 (11.82)	1 102 (84.50)	2 (0.15)	18 (1.39)	28 (2.13)	1 304 (100.00)
2012	154 (11.63)	1 147 (86.56)	1 (0.04)	10 (0.77)	14 (1.06)	1 326 (100.00)
2016	171 (11.89)	1 244 (86.56)	1 (0.04)	13 (0.89)	9 (0.63)	1 438 (100.00)
2020	153 (10.60)	1 245 (86.15)	6 (0.41)	23 (1.56)	19 (1.29)	1 445 (100.00)
2024	246 (12.84)	1 637 (85.42)	5 (0.24)	23 (1.18)	6 (0.32)	1 916 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

In the QLFS both employers and own-account workers were asked to report the number of employees in the firm. Whilst this answer was zero in the case of own-workers (as expected – as they stand for one-person businesses), it can be seen in Table 6 that for the employers in the formal non-agricultural sector, about 70% of them indicated there were 1-9 employees in the firm. In addition, about 15% and 10% of formal employers indicated there were 10-19 and 20-49 employees in the firm, respectively. Lastly, Table 7 shows that a very high share (about 95%) of employers in the informal non-agricultural sector reported they hired 1-9 employees in the firm. To conclude the discussions of Tables 6 and 7, informal sector employers were associated with smaller firm size, compared with formal sector employers.

Table 6: Number of employees in the firm as reported by employers in formal non-agricultural sector, selected years

	1 worker	2-4 workers	5-9 workers	10-19 workers	20-49 workers	50+ workers	Don't know	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets								
2008	66 (12.47)	189 (35.49)	135 (25.30)	73 (13.74)	50 (9.32)	18 (3.37)	2 (0.30)	532 (100.00)
2012	49 (10.47)	190 (40.94)	104 (22.46)	57 (12.20)	43 (9.18)	18 (3.88)	4 (0.87)	463 (100.00)
2016	38 (8.46)	175 (38.80)	102 (22.60)	71 (15.71)	32 (7.03)	22 (4.83)	12 (2.57)	451 (100.00)
2020	31 (6.75)	190 (41.09)	107 (23.24)	66 (14.21)	50 (10.91)	14 (2.94)	4 (0.85)	462 (100.00)
2024	52 (9.69)	197 (36.59)	108 (20.19)	87 (16.19)	50 (9.36)	34 (6.33)	9 (1.65)	537 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

Table 7: Number of employees in the firm as reported by employers in informal non-agricultural sector, selected years

	1 worker	2-4 workers	5-9 workers	10-19 workers	20-49 workers	50+ workers	Don't know	All
Number (1 000s), percentage share in brackets								
2008	88 (34.58)	134 (52.56)	20 (7.83)	2 (0.87)	4 (1.72)	5 (2.09)	1 (0.35)	255 (100.00)
2012	103 (32.11)	187 (58.21)	21 (6.67)	4 (1.12)	1 (0.43)	0 (0.08)	4 (1.39)	321 (100.00)
2016	84 (26.53)	197 (62.46)	25 (7.88)	3 (0.97)	1 (0.44)	2 (0.77)	3 (0.96)	315 (100.00)
2020	122 (40.57)	159 (52.95)	11 (3.61)	1 (0.18)	2 (0.66)	2 (0.72)	4 (1.30)	301 (100.00)
2024	126 (34.58)	196 (53.78)	23 (6.17)	6 (1.63)	4 (1.18)	10 (2.61)	0 (0.06)	365 (100.00)

Source: Author's own calculations using the 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024 QLFS third quarter data.

3. Sources of South African labour market data

The OHS (which took place in 1993-1999), LFS (which replaced the OHS in 2000, took place twice a year until 2007) and QLFS (which replaced LFS in 2008 and has been taking place four times a year) are the three key South African surveys that captured the most comprehensive information on the labour market status, work activities of the employed (e.g. sector, occupation, industry) and characteristics of the unemployed (e.g. prior work experience, time gap since last worked, duration of being jobless) who were aged 15 years or above at the time of the survey (StatsSA, 2008; Yu, 2008). Moreover, when the QLFS data is released, the earnings related data are withheld by StatsSA, and the data are only released later in a different dataset called the Labour Market Dynamics (LMD), which is the appended version of all four quarterly QLFS data from the same year.

The LFS asked a lot of question on non-income welfare of the households (e.g. ownership of assets and access to services), thereby causing the questionnaire to be unnecessarily long. Thus, these questions are now rather asked in the General Household Survey (GHS) which was introduced by StatsSA and has been conducted annually since 2002. Nonetheless, the GHS still asks a limited number of questions that help derive the labour market status of the household members, along with few questions on the earnings of the employed.

The Survey of Employed and Self-Employed (SESE) was introduced for the first time in 2009, with the primary aim of capturing information on the activities of non-VAT registered owners of enterprises (i.e. informal sector entrepreneurs), in areas such as business location, enterprise management, employment of workers, as well as revenue, expenditure and profit of the firms. At the time of writing, four waves of SESE data have been collected in 2009, 2013, 2017 and 2023.

The Volunteer Activities Survey (VAS) captures unofficial ‘work’ experience of people who performed activities for little or no payment, such as community policing, contributing to religious activities and fundraising. Note that the volunteers may or may not be employed at the time of the survey taking place. So far the VAS took place three times in total – in 2010, 2014 and 2018. On the other hand, the Survey of Activities of Young People (SAYP) was introduced for the first time in 2010 (it took place two more times in 2015 and 2019) to gather data on market, non-market, domestic and even school activities of children under the age of 18 years (Murozvi, 2024).

The Time Use Survey (TUS) has only taken place twice (2000 and 2010), and the aim of TUS is to collect information on how the household members (only a maximum of two members per household were allowed to take part in the survey) spent their time on reproductive activities (e.g. caring for children, caring for household members, cooking, cleaning and collecting water and fuel), leisure activities and productive activities (e.g. paid and unpaid work), with the aid of the recall time-diary approach. Each respondent was required to list their activities for a continuous 24-period in 30-minute intervals. This 24-hour period starts at 04:00 the day prior to the interview until 04:00 on the day of the interview. All activities, regardless of whether taking place consecutively or simultaneously, were recorded for each 30-minute period (Nackerdien, 2021). In other words, TUS collects information on people (who were employed) who worked outside the typical days or hours, e.g. working at midnight or weekends.

Looking at other StatSA surveys, the primary aim of both the Income and Expenditure Survey (IES – it took place five times since the advent of democracy, in 1995, 2000, 2005, 2010/2011 and 2022/2023, but at the time of writing the 2022/2023 data has not yet been released to the public) and Living Conditions Survey (LCS – it took place twice in 2008/2009 and 2014/2015) is to collect detailed information on household income and expenditure, and thus only a very limited number of questions were asked in connection with labour market outcomes and activities.

Next, the National Household Transport Survey (NHTS) took place three times so far (2003, 2013 and 2020), and the primary aim of this survey is to capture information on transport mode and travel time on a wide range of activities, with one of these activities being work (Kerr, 2017) . In fact, one section of the survey is specifically devoted to work related travel patterns, with numerous questions being asked, such as whether the respondent worked in the past seven days, transport mode to go to workplace and leave workplace (e.g. private motor vehicle, bus, train, travel time, transport cost).

Table 8: South African surveys that asked questions on labour market activities, 1995-2024

	<u>OHS</u>	<u>LFS</u>	<u>QLFS</u>	<u>LMD</u>	<u>GHS</u>	<u>SESE</u>	<u>VAS</u>	<u>SAYP</u>	<u>TUS</u>	<u>IES</u>	<u>LCS</u>	<u>NHTS</u>	<u>CS</u>	<u>Census</u>	<u>NIDS</u>	<u>NIDS-CRAM</u>
1995	x									x						
1996	x													x		
1997	x															
1998	x															
1999	x															
2000		x							x	x						
2001		x												x		
2002		x			x											
2003		x			x							x				
2004		x			x											
2005		x			x					x						
2006		x			x											
2007		x			x								x			
2008			x	x	x						x				x	
2009			x	x	x	x										
2010			x	x	x		x	x	x	x					x	
2011			x	x	x									x		
2012			x	x	x										x	
2013			x	x	x	x						x				
2014			x	x	x		x				x				x	
2015			x	x	x			x								
2016			x	x	x								x			
2017			x	x	x	x									x	
2018			x	x	x		x									
2019			x	x	x			x								
2020			x	x	x							x				x
2021			x	x	x											x
2022			x	x	x					x				x		
2023			x	x	x	x										
2024			x	x	x											

Source: Author's own compilations.

Moving on to the Census, since the advent of democracy, it took place four times – in 1996, 2001, 2011 and 2022. Whilst the primary aim of Census is to capture information on non-income welfare just like the GHS, it also asked a few questions to capture the labour market status, work activities of the employed and characteristics of unemployed persons. On the other hand, the Community Survey (CS) – unofficially known as ‘mini-Census’ – took place in a year between two consecutive censuses (in 2007 – between Census 2001 and Census 2011; in 2016 – between Census 2011 and Census 2022), and asked similar questions as the Census.

At the time of writing, there are two national panel datasets in South Africa, namely the National Income Dynamics Study (NIDS) and National Income Dynamics Study – Coronavirus Rapid Mobile Survey (NIDS-CRAM). Both surveys were not conducted by StatsSA but rather led by the Southern African Labour and Development Research Unit (SALDRU) based at the University of Cape Town. First, the NIDS-CRAM survey took place five times (2020 April, 2020 June, 2020 October, 2021 January and 2021 March), with the primary aim of investigating the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on labour market and various other socio-economic outcomes, such as household income, child hunger and access to social grants (Ingle et al., 2020).

As far as the NIDS is concerned, the main objective of this panel data survey is to measure and understand who is ahead and who is behind in the country, as well as why some people have made progress whereas others did not (UCT, 2009). At the time of writing, NIDS took place five times, in 2008, 2010/2011, 2012, 2014/2015 and 2017. There were four questionnaires in total, namely household, child, adult and proxy questionnaires. Focusing on the adult questionnaire, section E of this questionnaire asked a lot of questions on the labour market activities of the adults, ranging from labour market status, work activities (if employed), characteristics of unemployed (e.g. time since last worked, duration of seeking work). Note that this section has a sub-section that is specifically devoted to capture information on casual work activities of the employed, but in the StatsSA surveys, only one question was asked on casual work in OHS 1999 as well as LFS 2000-2007 but this question was dropped since the introduction of the QLFS in 2008 (Yu, 2007 & 2008).

To conclude, Table 8 above shows the various StatsSA Censuses and surveys (along with the SALDRU-led NIDS and NIDS-CRAM panel data surveys) that have been taking place since 1995. Note that all these censuses and surveys captured labour market information, but OHS, LFS and QLFS remain the three surveys that have captured such information most comprehensively.

4. Suggestions on areas for possible further improvement in the QLFS questionnaire

In this section, various suggestions are raised on certain questions that can be added to the QLFS questionnaire. Even though one major opportunity cost of these recommendations is that the questionnaire would become longer and thereby increases the likelihood of interviewee fatigue, it may also be worthwhile for StatsSA to consider dropping relatively less important questions (if any) from the existing questionnaire, to ensure the length of the questionnaire would become more or less the same overall (if there is a possibility that the suggestions below would be implemented in future).

4.1 Section 1: Demographic information

Until 2007, the OHS and LFS both asked the respondents to declare the language they spoke most often at home (i.e. home language). However, this question has been dropped since the introduction

of QLFS in 2008. Even though a similar question (preferred language) was asked in both the NIDS household questionnaire and GHS, as NIDS does not take place annually and it has been eight years since the last NIDS was conducted whereas GHS does not collect labour market information as comprehensively as QLFS does, it is strongly recommended the home language question be added to the QLFS questionnaire, so that it is possible to more precisely estimate empirically the impact of home language on labour force participation probability, employment likelihood and even earnings (i.e. research topics such as employment discrimination and wage discrimination). In the South African literature, in recent years that have hardly been local studies done on the impact of home language and even English language proficiency on labour market outcomes, other than relatively older studies done by Posel & Casale (2011), Fransman (2014) as well as McKenzie & Muller (2017).

4.2 Section 2: Economic activities

It is strongly recommended that children aged 5-17 years are also allowed to answer the QLFS Section 2 questions (in fact, this recommendation would not result in any additional questions being added to the questionnaire), so that there is no need to wait for 4-5 years before the same information would be available in the SAYP data (which is linked to the QLFS data), and subsequently it would be possible to estimate the correlation between the labour market outcomes of child and adult members coming from the same households, for example, whether the presence of child labour is associated with a lower labour force participation likelihood of the adult members who reside in the same household. As of now, few studies have analysed the SAYP data (e.g. Budlender & Bosch, 2002; De Wet, 2013; Yu et al. 2025).

Moreover, in Question 2.4 of the same section (there are currently three sub-questions – 2.4(a)-(c)), it is suggested that 2.4(d) be added by asking the respondents to declare whether they were involved in unpaid work at the premises other than household businesses (i.e. volunteering activities) in the past seven days. This question was asked in the VAS (which is also linked to the QLFS data). However, as VAS has not been conducted since 2018, yet some recent empirical studies have found that there was some association between volunteering status and labour market status of the working-age population (e.g. Niyimbanira, 2015; Fondling et al. 2023), it is important to include a question relating to volunteering in the QLFS, so that more research using more updated data can be conducted in this regard, for example, whether jobless people's active involvement in volunteering activities would keep them actively seeking work in the labour market instead of ending up as discouraged workseekers or even inactive.

4.3 Section 3: Unemployment and economic inactivity

Currently the QLFS does not ask any questions on whether the survey participants turned down any job offers in the past four weeks as well as the main reason for not accepting these job offers. Nonetheless, these two questions were asked in Section E of the NIDS adult questionnaire (Questions Eg8 and Eg9 respectively). It is strongly recommended that these two questions are added to the QLFS, so that we could understand the South African labour market dynamics better, in particularly issues such as the high job reservation wage, geographical mismatch between the area of residence of the job applicant and the area where the job offer is available, and even the decision to pursue further education by turning down a job offer (in line with the arguments of the human capital theory).

4.4 Section 4: Main work activities

Since the TUS captured information on work activities after office hours, it is suggested that one simple question be added in the QLFS, such as ‘did you work between 17:00 and 08:00 for at least one day in the past seven days?’, so as to capture flexi-time work activities and whether workers who worked after hours are associated with a wage premium (after controlling for differences in other characteristics), especially given the fact that TUS has not been conducted again since 2010. Thus, the availability of updated data on after-office-hours work activities is important.

Next, the QLFS asked a lot of questions (e.g. contract type, work hours, social benefits) which enabled the derivation of an employment quality index (Yu, 2020). However, job quality consists of two dimensions, mainly employment quality and work quality. Thus, it is recommended that the QLFS should also include some questions in connection with work quality, such as work autonomy, physical working conditions and risk of accidents, so that in future it is possible to conduct research on areas such as the derivation of a work quality index and job quality index of employees in the South African labour market.

Lastly, in this section of the QLFS, relatively more questions were asked to the employees (e.g. paid sick or annual leave, maternity/paternity leave, medical aid benefits, job permanence), but very few questions were asked to employers and own-account workers, primarily in connection with the enterprise registration and VAT/income tax registration status. Thus, it is recommended that a few more questions (that are similar to the SESE questions) are added to the QLFS, such as business location or renting status (i.e. 2023 SESE Question 18); financial records (i.e. 2023 SESE Question 24); number of months in the past year that the business operated (i.e. 2023 SESE Question 28) and financial source to start the business (i.e. 2023 SESE Questions 37-38).

With the addition of these questions (assuming it would not lead to serious interviewee fatigue), it would be possible to conduct deeper research on the business activities of formal sector firms, just like the recent studies on informal sector enterprises (e.g. Fourie & Kerr, 2017; Fourie, 2018; Murozvi et al. 2022), especially given the fact that Table 4 earlier has found that a high 60% share of employers operated their businesses in the formal sector.

5. Conclusion

This research study has examined the various Censuses and surveys that captured limited to comprehensive information on the labour market outcomes and activities of the population in South Africa, before various recommendations were made to further improve the QLFS questionnaire, especially given the fact that some surveys have not been conducted for a relatively long time (e.g. NIDS and TUS) whereas other surveys have still been taking place regularly. However, one has to wait for a number of years before these survey datasets would be available (e.g. SAYP, SESE and VAS), but these surveys have asked some important questions that are currently not asked in the QLFS.

It is hoped that the recommendations would be helpful to capture labour market information even more thoroughly so as to empirically derive more robust findings on the South African labour market, in areas such as the impact of child labour on labour market outcomes of adult members, the correlation between volunteering status and labour market status, after-office-hour work activities, work quality, job quality, as well as business operations characteristics of formal sector employers.

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